the understudy bit even as it was I who had encouraged him on such an arrangement.

The Governor’s Office

The governor’s office on the eighteenth floor of the Reserve Bank’s central office in the Fort area of Mumbai is spacious and comfortable, elegant but not luxurious. There was an ambitious greening project undertaken for the entire tower structure of the central office in 2009–10 which doubled as an opportunity to redesign the layout of the executive office floors of the building. The old small, steel-frame windows were replaced by floor-to-lintel-level chrome and glass windows which let in a lot of light but kept the heat out. You look out the window and you could see the Government Mint, the colonial era customs house and the ships docked in the Bombay port. I used to joke with my staff that the Reserve Bank must allow me the use of the governor’s office for at least three months after I stepped down so that I could enjoy the comfort and elegance of the beautiful office without the burdens of the job.

The eighteenth floor houses the governor and his front office; there is also a large, handsomely appointed conference room, modernized as part of the greening project. Across the aisle from the governor’s office is a private lounge for meeting visitors, with a separate dining space should the governor be hosting a small meal for friends or guests. On the wall adjacent to the dining table is the governor’s gallery, portraits of all the past governors, seemingly keeping an eye on the current incumbent who will, in course of time, join their club. You look out the window on the lounge side and you can see several behemoths of the Indian financial sector—SBI, UBI, BSE (Bombay Stock Exchange)—as well as the high court, the naval base and the Mazagon Docks. From the air-conditioned comfort and calm of the eighteenth floor, the hustle and bustle and the chaos and confusion of Mumbai’s financial district looks orderly and organized!

There is an additional small office room on the eighteenth floor, behind the governor’s office, which is allotted to visiting dignitaries. The Reserve